

S3LFM@DE Solutions

PERSONAL STUDY & PRACTICE MANUAL

Creative • Clerical • Events • Business • Technology

A self-paced refresher and skill-building guide designed around the services you offer now and the technical skills you want to rebuild next.

How to use this book: read a short section, practice it immediately, save versions of your work, and review what changed. Keep your live business website separate from all practice files.

Study Roadmap

- **Phase 1 - Office & Clerical:** Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, document formatting, data entry, professional correspondence.
- **Phase 2 - Creative Services:** Graphic-design fundamentals, flyers, programs, invitations, business cards, social graphics.
- **Phase 3 - Client Services:** Resumes, cover letters, proofreading, research assistance, bookkeeping support, event planning.
- **Phase 4 - Web Refresh:** HTML, CSS, responsive design, safe experimentation, basic JavaScript concepts.
- **Phase 5 - Help Desk:** Troubleshooting process, Windows, hardware, networking, printers, accounts, security basics.
- **Phase 6 - Python:** Syntax refresh, control flow, functions, data structures, files, errors, automation projects.
- **Phase 7 - Business Growth:** Workflow, customer experience, pricing discipline, portfolio building, quality control.

Recommended rhythm: 30-60 minutes reading + 30-60 minutes hands-on practice. Stop while you are still curious, then return the next day.

1. Microsoft Word & Professional Documents

Purpose: Refresh the document-production skills behind resumes, letters, programs, forms, and client deliverables.

Key Terms

- **Styles:** Reusable formatting rules for headings, body text, lists, and other document elements.
- **Margins:** Blank space around the page that affects readability and print layout.
- **Hierarchy:** Visual order that tells the reader what to notice first, second, and third.
- **Section break:** A break that allows different page settings inside one document.

Document structure

Start with content before decoration. Decide the document's purpose, audience, required sections, and reading order. Use headings consistently instead of manually formatting every title.

Professional documents usually benefit from restrained typography, consistent spacing, clear alignment, and enough white space. A polished document should feel easy to scan.

Formatting habits

Use paragraph spacing rather than repeated blank lines. Use tabs or tables for alignment rather than strings of spaces. Keep font choices limited and intentional.

Practice page numbers, headers/footers, tables, columns, bullets, borders, and section breaks. Learn to reveal formatting marks when a document behaves strangely.

Hands-On Practice

1. Open one of your resume practice files and create Elegant, Classic, and Modern versions.
2. Rebuild a church program from a blank Word document.
3. Create a one-page client intake form using tables, borders, and shading.
4. Turn a plain business letter into a branded S3LFM@DE-style document.

Client Challenge

A client sends a messy two-page document with inconsistent fonts, spacing, and headings. Reformat it into a clean professional document without changing the meaning.

Quick Quiz

1. Why are Word styles better than manually formatting every heading?
2. When would you use a section break?
3. What is the difference between alignment and indentation?
4. Name two ways to improve readability without adding decoration.

My notes:

2. Microsoft Excel & Spreadsheet Skills

Purpose: Strengthen the spreadsheet skills behind budgets, trackers, bookkeeping support, invoices, schedules, and data entry.

Key Terms

- **Cell reference:** The address of a cell, such as A1.
- **Formula:** An expression beginning with = that calculates a result.
- **Function:** A built-in calculation such as SUM, AVERAGE, IF, or COUNTIF.
- **Data validation:** Rules that control what users can enter.
- **PivotTable:** A tool for summarizing and exploring structured data.

Build clean tables

Use one header row, one record per row, and one field per column. Avoid merged cells inside working data tables. Keep dates, currency, and numbers stored as real values rather than decorative text.

Use tables, filters, freeze panes, conditional formatting, and data validation to make sheets easier to use.

Formula refresh

Practice SUM, AVERAGE, MIN, MAX, COUNT, COUNTA, IF, SUMIF/SUMIFS, COUNTIF/COUNTIFS, XLOOKUP where available, and basic date arithmetic.

Always test formulas with simple values you can calculate mentally. Copy formulas carefully and learn the difference between relative references like A1 and absolute references like \$A\$1.

Hands-On Practice

5. Modify the Event Budget workbook and add a 10% contingency line.
6. Create a monthly income/expense tracker from scratch.
7. Add status dropdowns and conditional formatting to a project tracker.
8. Create an invoice where quantity × rate calculates line totals and payments reduce the balance.

Client Challenge

A client wants a tracker showing project name, due date, status, price, amount paid, and balance. Build it with formulas, dropdowns, and visual status cues.

Quick Quiz

1. What character begins an Excel formula?
2. What does \$A\$1 mean?
3. Why should working data usually avoid merged cells?
4. What is data validation useful for?

My notes:

3. Microsoft PowerPoint & Presentation Design

Purpose: Create clear, attractive presentations for businesses, churches, events, and organizations.

Key Terms

- **Slide master:** Central control for repeated slide formatting.
- **Layout:** Arrangement of placeholders and content.
- **Contrast:** Difference that helps important content stand out.
- **Speaker notes:** Presenter-only notes attached to slides.

Think in slides

One slide should communicate one main idea. Avoid shrinking paragraphs to fit. Convert dense information into short statements, diagrams, tables, or multiple slides.

Use consistent title placement, typography, margins, and visual language. The presentation should feel like one system, not unrelated pages.

Present, don't decorate

Use animation sparingly and intentionally. Choose images and graphics that support the message. Keep contrast high enough for projected viewing.

Hands-On Practice

9. Create a five-slide small-business introduction.
10. Create a church-event presentation with title, schedule, speakers, announcements, and closing slide.
11. Take one ugly slide and improve only hierarchy, spacing, and alignment.
12. Create two versions of the same deck: elegant and colorful.

Client Challenge

A local organization needs a seven-slide sponsorship presentation. Build a clear story from problem → event → audience → sponsorship options → contact.

Quick Quiz

1. What is the purpose of Slide Master?
2. Why is tiny text usually a warning sign?
3. What does visual consistency accomplish?
4. When should animation be used?

My notes:

4. Microsoft Access & Database Thinking

Purpose: Refresh relational-database concepts for organized records, forms, queries, and reports.

Key Terms

- **Table:** Stores records about one type of thing.
- **Primary key:** Unique identifier for each record.
- **Foreign key:** Field that connects a record to another table.
- **Query:** A saved request that filters, combines, or calculates data.
- **Relationship:** Defined connection between tables.

Relational thinking

Do not store everything in one giant table. Separate Customers, Services, Orders, and Payments, then connect them with keys.

A one-to-many relationship means one customer can have many orders, while each order belongs to one customer.

Forms, queries, reports

Forms make data entry easier. Queries answer questions. Reports format database information for viewing or printing. Learn to separate data storage from presentation.

Hands-On Practice

13. Import the Access-practice CSV tables into a blank Access database.
14. Create primary keys and relationships.
15. Build a query showing only In Progress orders.
16. Create a customer form and an order-summary report.

Client Challenge

Build a simple database for an event planner: Clients, Events, Vendors, and Payments. Decide the keys and relationships before creating forms.

Quick Quiz

1. What is a primary key?
2. What is a foreign key?
3. Why separate Customers and Orders?
4. What is the difference between a query and a report?

My notes:

5. Graphic Design Fundamentals

Purpose: Improve flyers, invitations, programs, business cards, social graphics, and document aesthetics.

Key Terms

- **Hierarchy:** Visual ranking of information.
- **Alignment:** Placing elements along shared visual lines.
- **Contrast:** Difference in size, color, weight, or shape.
- **White space:** Intentional empty space that improves clarity.
- **Typography:** Selection and arrangement of type.

Design before effects

Good design is not the number of decorations you can add. Start with hierarchy, alignment, spacing, readability, and purpose.

Use a limited palette and limited font family. Let one element lead. Make secondary information quieter.

Design for the audience

A memorial program, children's birthday flyer, corporate proposal, and church revival flyer should not look identical. Style should match the audience and emotional purpose.

Hands-On Practice

17. Take one flyer and make Elegant, Classic, Modern, and Fun versions.
18. Practice using only two fonts and three colors.
19. Recreate a design using a grid.
20. Print or zoom out and check whether the main message is still obvious.

Client Challenge

A client asks for 'elegant but exciting.' Create a design using restrained colors, strong typography, and one energetic accent rather than filling the page with effects.

Quick Quiz

1. Define hierarchy.
2. Why is white space useful?
3. What happens when everything is bold?
4. Why should style change with audience?

My notes:

6. Resumes, Cover Letters & Professional Bios

Purpose: Produce polished career documents while keeping the client's facts accurate.

Key Terms

- **ATS:** Applicant tracking system used by many employers.
- **Achievement statement:** Bullet describing an action and result.
- **Transferable skill:** Skill useful across roles.
- **Professional summary:** Short overview of relevant experience and strengths.

Resume editing

Prioritize clarity, accurate facts, relevant experience, consistent dates, and strong action verbs. Do not invent credentials or accomplishments.

Decorative resumes may be appropriate in some contexts, but a clean text structure is safer when ATS compatibility matters.

Cover letters and bios

A cover letter should connect the applicant's experience to the role instead of repeating the resume. A professional bio can be written in different lengths and tones depending on where it will appear.

Hands-On Practice

21. Rewrite three weak resume bullets into stronger factual achievement statements.
22. Create one ATS-friendly resume and one visually styled version.
23. Write a short, medium, and long professional bio from the same facts.
24. Proofread a cover letter for tone, grammar, and consistency.

Client Challenge

A client has ten years of experience but a cluttered resume. Reorganize it around relevant skills and accomplishments without changing any facts.

Quick Quiz

1. What is an ATS?
2. Why should you never invent accomplishments?
3. What should a cover letter add beyond a resume?
4. When might you create multiple bio lengths?

My notes:

7. Proofreading, Editing & Research Assistance

Purpose: Provide ethical writing support through correction, organization, source handling, and formatting.

Key Terms

- **Proofreading:** Final correction of spelling, punctuation, grammar, and surface errors.
- **Copyediting:** Improving clarity, consistency, grammar, and style.
- **Citation:** Credit identifying the source of information.
- **Paraphrase:** Restating an idea in new wording while preserving meaning and attribution.

Editing workflow

Separate editing passes: first meaning and organization, then sentence clarity, then grammar/punctuation, then final proof. Trying to fix everything at once makes errors easier to miss.

Preserve the writer's intended meaning and voice unless the client asks for a different tone.

Academic boundaries

Offer tutoring, research assistance, source organization, proofreading, citation help, and formatting. Do not misrepresent work as the student's own when the assignment requires their authorship.

Hands-On Practice

25. Proofread the exercise in your practice pack.
26. Create a style sheet listing preferred capitalization and terminology.
27. Format a sample references page consistently.
28. Turn rough notes into a professional outline without writing a graded assignment for the student.

Client Challenge

A customer sends a rough research draft. Correct grammar, flag unclear claims, organize headings, and standardize citations while leaving the customer's ideas and authorship intact.

Quick Quiz

1. How does proofreading differ from copyediting?
2. What is a paraphrase?
3. Why use multiple editing passes?
4. Name two ethical forms of academic assistance.

My notes:

8. Bookkeeping Support & Invoicing

Purpose: Build confidence with organized financial records while recognizing the boundary between bookkeeping support and professional tax/accounting advice.

Key Terms

- **Revenue:** Money earned by the business.
- **Expense:** Cost incurred by the business.
- **Accounts receivable:** Money customers owe the business.
- **Reconciliation:** Comparing records against another source such as a bank statement.
- **Invoice:** Request for payment describing services, amounts, and terms.

Recordkeeping basics

Consistent categories and dates matter. Keep source documents, record transactions promptly, and separate business records from personal records.

An invoice should clearly identify the service, amount, payment status, and due information. Spreadsheet formulas can calculate subtotals and balances.

Know the boundary

Bookkeeping support can include organization, data entry, categorization support, invoice tracking, and reconciliations within your competence. Tax preparation and regulated professional advice require separate training and applicable credentials/registrations.

Hands-On Practice

29. Reconcile a fictional expense list against a fictional bank statement.
30. Build an invoice from scratch in Excel.
31. Create an accounts-receivable tracker.
32. Create monthly categories and summarize spending with SUMIFS or a PivotTable.

Client Challenge

A client gives you a folder of receipts and a transaction export. Organize the records into a clean monthly workbook and flag items needing clarification rather than guessing.

Quick Quiz

1. What is accounts receivable?
2. What does reconciliation mean?
3. What information belongs on an invoice?
4. Why separate business and personal records?

My notes:

9. Event Planning & Coordination

Purpose: Practice the organizational systems behind timelines, vendors, budgets, guest management, and day-of coordination.

Key Terms

- **Run of show:** Detailed chronological event schedule.
- **Contingency plan:** Backup response for foreseeable problems.
- **Vendor:** External provider such as caterer, DJ, venue, or photographer.
- **Scope:** What your planning service does and does not include.

Plan backward

Start with the event date and work backward into milestones. Track decisions, deposits, due dates, vendor contacts, guest counts, and dependencies.

A beautiful event still needs operational detail: setup windows, deliveries, contacts, payment status, accessibility, weather plans, and cleanup.

Client communication

Confirm decisions in writing. Keep a change log when scope changes. Use checklists so important tasks are not dependent on memory.

Hands-On Practice

33. Create a 12-month wedding timeline.
34. Create a birthday event budget with contingency.
35. Build a vendor contact and payment tracker.
36. Write a day-of run of show with setup, guest arrival, program, and breakdown.

Client Challenge

A 75-person anniversary dinner has a venue, caterer, DJ, decorator, and photographer. Build the planning system that would keep every deadline and contact organized.

Quick Quiz

1. What is a run of show?
2. Why plan backward from the event date?
3. What belongs in a contingency plan?
4. Why document client changes?

My notes:

10. HTML & CSS Refresher

Purpose: Rebuild front-end confidence safely using practice files rather than your live business site.

Key Terms

- **HTML:** Markup that describes page structure and content.
- **CSS:** Rules controlling visual presentation and layout.
- **Selector:** Pattern used to target elements for styling.
- **Box model:** Content, padding, border, and margin around an element.
- **Responsive design:** Layout that adapts to different screen sizes.

HTML structure

Use semantic elements where practical: header, nav, main, section, article, footer, headings, paragraphs, lists, forms, and buttons. Keep nesting valid and readable.

Attributes such as id, class, name, href, and src can connect elements to styling, scripts, forms, and resources. In practice projects, experiment freely; in production, understand dependencies before renaming them.

CSS practice

Refresh selectors, cascade, specificity, inheritance, box model, flexbox, grid, typography, spacing, borders, pseudo-classes, and media queries.

Use browser developer tools to inspect styles and experiment before changing source files.

Hands-On Practice

37. Open one HTML/CSS practice project and change only CSS.
38. Rebuild its layout with CSS Grid instead of Flexbox, or vice versa.
39. Create a mobile media query.
40. Add a second section using semantic HTML and style it consistently.

Client Challenge

Take a simple service card and make it responsive at desktop and phone widths without changing its message.

Quick Quiz

1. What does HTML control?
2. What does CSS control?
3. Name the four parts of the box model.
4. What is a media query?

My notes:

11. Help Desk & Computer Troubleshooting

Purpose: Rebuild a disciplined support mindset for Windows, hardware, networking, software, printers, accounts, and common user issues.

Key Terms

- **Troubleshooting:** Structured process of identifying, testing, resolving, and documenting a problem.
- **DNS:** System that maps domain names to network addresses.
- **Driver:** Software that lets the operating system communicate with hardware.
- **Safe Mode:** Diagnostic startup mode with limited drivers/services.
- **Least privilege:** Giving users only the access needed for their work.

Troubleshooting process

Start by identifying the exact symptom, scope, timing, recent changes, and error messages. Reproduce the issue when safe. Form a theory, test the least disruptive likely cause, verify the fix, and document what happened.

Do not jump straight to reinstalling software or resetting systems. Preserve user data and understand impact before destructive steps.

Core practice areas

Refresh Task Manager, Device Manager, Windows Update, Event Viewer basics, user accounts, file permissions, startup apps, disk/storage, printers, browsers, and application repair.

Networking practice should include IP addresses, DHCP, DNS, gateways, Wi-Fi, Ethernet, ping, ipconfig, and distinguishing 'no internet' from 'one website does not load.'

Hands-On Practice

41. Write a troubleshooting checklist for 'computer is slow.'
42. Diagnose a fictional printer-not-printing ticket.
43. Use ipconfig and ping on your own machine only to observe normal output.
44. Create a support-ticket template: symptom, environment, steps tried, result, resolution.

Client Challenge

A user says, 'The internet is down.' Ask the questions and list the tests that distinguish Wi-Fi, local network, DNS, browser, and single-site problems.

Quick Quiz

1. Why should you identify recent changes?
2. What is DNS?
3. What is a driver?

4. Why verify the fix after the symptom disappears?

My notes:

12. Python for a Returning Programmer

Purpose: Learn Python as a practical automation language while refreshing general programming concepts.

Key Terms

- **Variable:** Name referring to a value.
- **List:** Ordered mutable collection.
- **Dictionary:** Key-value mapping.
- **Function:** Reusable block of code that can accept inputs and return a value.
- **Exception:** Runtime event representing an error or unusual condition.
- **Module:** Python file or library that can be imported.

Start with the language

Refresh numbers, strings, booleans, lists, dictionaries, sets, tuples, conditionals, loops, functions, imports, files, exceptions, and classes.

Python uses indentation as part of its syntax. Write small programs and run them often rather than building a huge program before testing.

Use Python for useful work

Once the basics feel natural, automate repetitive tasks: rename files, organize folders, read CSV data, summarize records, validate inputs, generate simple reports, and parse logs.

Use virtual environments for project dependencies and read error tracebacks from the bottom upward to find the immediate failure.

Hands-On Practice

45. Write a program that calculates an invoice subtotal and balance.
46. Create a list of service names and print them with a loop.
47. Read a CSV practice file and count its rows.
48. Write a function that cleans a customer name by trimming extra spaces and applying title case.
49. Create a file organizer using a practice folder, never important personal files.

Client Challenge

Build a command-line project estimator: ask for a service, quantity/hours, and rate; calculate a subtotal; validate bad input; print a clean summary.

Quick Quiz

1. Why is indentation important in Python?
2. What is the difference between a list and dictionary?
3. What does a function return?

4. What is an exception?

My notes:

13. Business Operations, Portfolio & Growth

Purpose: Turn technical skill into consistent professional service.

Key Terms

- **Scope of work:** Written definition of what a project includes.
- **Revision:** Requested change to work already produced.
- **Turnaround:** Expected time required to complete work.
- **Portfolio:** Curated examples demonstrating capabilities.
- **Quality assurance:** Final checks performed before delivery.

Professional workflow

Use a repeatable flow: request → clarify scope → quote/invoice → collect required files/payment → produce → proof/revision → final delivery → archive.

Your portal-first rule supports organization because it keeps the official request and project information in one place.

Portfolio ethics and growth

Clearly label concept/sample projects as samples. Do not present fictional samples as real customers or reviews. Replace samples with strong real work over time when you have permission to show it.

Track what customers request most often. Improve templates and checklists around repeat services. Growth is easier when quality is repeatable rather than dependent on memory.

Hands-On Practice

50. Create a final-delivery checklist for every service.
51. Create a naming convention for customer files and versions.
52. Review ten portfolio samples and choose the strongest five.
53. Write a scope checklist for event planning and a separate one for resume services.

Client Challenge

A customer asks for several additions after approving the original scope. Practice responding professionally, documenting the new work, and deciding whether a revised quote is needed.

Quick Quiz

1. What is scope creep?
2. Why keep versioned files?
3. Why label concept work?
4. What should happen before final delivery?

My notes:

Quiz Answer Key & Review Notes

Word

Styles create consistent reusable formatting; section breaks allow different page/section settings; alignment positions paragraphs while indentation offsets text; readability improves through hierarchy, spacing, contrast, and consistent typography.

Excel

Formulas begin with =; \$A\$1 is an absolute reference; merged cells interfere with sorting/filtering and structured data; validation restricts/standardizes entries.

PowerPoint

Slide Master controls repeated design; tiny text usually means too much content; consistency improves comprehension; animation should support meaning, not distract.

Access

Primary keys uniquely identify records; foreign keys connect tables; separation reduces duplication; queries retrieve/transform data while reports present it.

Design

Hierarchy ranks importance; white space improves clarity; if everything is bold nothing stands out; style should fit audience and purpose.

Career docs

ATS means applicant tracking system; never invent facts; cover letters connect experience to a role; different bio lengths fit different uses.

Editing

Proofreading fixes surface errors; copyediting also improves clarity/style; paraphrasing restates with attribution; multiple passes reduce missed errors.

Bookkeeping

AR is money customers owe; reconciliation compares records; invoices identify services/amounts/terms; separation improves record clarity.

Events

Run of show is a detailed event timeline; backward planning reveals deadlines; contingency plans cover likely disruptions; written changes protect clarity.

HTML/CSS

HTML structures content; CSS styles it; box model is content/padding/border/margin; media queries apply styles based on conditions such as width.

Help Desk

Recent changes often explain new symptoms; DNS resolves names; drivers connect OS and hardware; verification ensures the real problem is solved.

Python

Indentation defines blocks; lists are ordered collections while dictionaries map keys to values; functions may return values; exceptions represent runtime errors.

Business

Scope creep is work expanding beyond agreement; versions protect history; samples must be labeled honestly; final delivery needs QA and correct files.

Recommended Free Reference Shelf

- **Microsoft Learn / Microsoft Support:** Use current Microsoft training for Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, Windows, and related Microsoft tools.
- **Python Documentation:** The official Python Tutorial is especially appropriate for programmers who already understand basic programming concepts.
- **U.S. Small Business Administration:** Use the SBA Business Guide for bookkeeping/finance basics, marketing, operations, compliance awareness, and business-growth resources.
- **CompTIA A+ Objectives:** Use current A+ objectives as a checklist for help-desk domains: hardware, networking, operating systems, security, troubleshooting, and support procedures.
- **Your S3LFM@DE Practice Packs:** Use the Word, Excel, Access-import, PDF, and HTML/CSS samples already created as hands-on exercises.

90-Day Self-Study Plan

- **Weeks 1-2:** Word + document design: resumes, letters, programs, forms.
- **Weeks 3-4:** Excel: formulas, trackers, invoices, bookkeeping sheets.
- **Week 5:** PowerPoint + visual presentation.
- **Week 6:** Access + database relationships/forms/queries.
- **Weeks 7-8:** Graphic design + portfolio projects + event-planning documents.
- **Week 9:** HTML/CSS refresher using only practice projects.
- **Weeks 10-11:** Help Desk fundamentals and troubleshooting scenarios.
- **Week 12:** Python foundations and one small automation project.
- **Ongoing:** Business operations, portfolio review, client communication, and quality control.

Final Rule

READ IT. TRY IT. BREAK THE PRACTICE COPY. FIX IT. SAVE THE VERSION. DO IT AGAIN.

The goal is not to memorize every command. The goal is to rebuild the habit of figuring things out.